

## Essay 1: Arguing A Position Topic Proposal Activity

In order for me to get a sense of what everyone would like to write about for this first essay, I am tasking each of you with writing me a brief proposal. This proposal should clearly outline the issue that you want to write about and it should clearly present your position on this topic. In addition, I want to know why you are interested in this topic and what—if any—existing knowledge you have about the issue.

The Saint Martin's Guide, chapter 6 contains a useful exercise to assist you in choosing an issue to write about:

1. When choosing an issue, keep in mind that it must be:
  - a) controversial — an issue that people disagree about;
  - b) arguable — a matter of opinion on which there is no absolute proof or authority;
  - c) one that you can research, as necessary, in the time you have;
  - d) one that you care about.

Choosing an issue that you have a special interest in or some knowledge about usually works best. Also, if you are thinking about addressing an issue of national concern, focus on a local or a very specific aspect of it. For example, if writing about “immigration,” “abortion,” or “gun control,” while these are certainly controversial, they are also too broad. You must narrow your topic by focusing on a particular immigration law being proposed by a particular state—as an example—or a specific ruling regarding guns recently passed by California—for instance.

If you are still struggling to come up with ideas, here are some suggestions by SMG:

1. Should particular courses, community service, or an internship be a graduation requirement at your high school or college?
2. Should students attending public colleges be required to pay higher tuition fees if they have been full-time students but have not graduated within four years?
3. Should your large lecture or online courses have frequent (weekly or biweekly) exams instead of only a midterm and final?
4. Should children raised in this country whose parents are undocumented be given an opportunity to become citizens after finishing college or serving in the military?
5. Should the football conference that your school (or another school in the area) participates in be allowed to expand?
6. Should you look primarily for a job that is well paid or for a job that is personally fulfilling or socially responsible?
7. Should the racial, ethnic, or gender makeup of a police force resemble the makeup of the community it serves?
8. Should public employees be allowed to unionize and to bargain collectively for improved working conditions, pay, or pensions?

9. Should the state or federal government provide job training to those who are unemployed but able to work?

Some other suggestions might include:

10. Do Video games cause children to be more violent?
11. Should students be allowed to use AI to assist in their academics if used responsibly?
12. Should healthcare OR college be made more affordable or even free?

There are many topics that you can choose from, which is why this proposal is necessary. I will read them and comment back, letting each of you know if this topic is valid for this essay.

Your Task:

1. In about 200 words (about 100 for each topic A&B), explain two issues (one primary topic and one back up in case the primary is too difficult) that you feel confident that you could use to write this essay.
2. Then, clearly articulate your position. You may also include a brief comment on whether you are fixed in your stance regarding this issue, or if you would be open to changing your stance depending on the information you encounter during your research.
3. Next, describe your current knowledge regarding this issue and your present interest in it. What do you already know that is determining your position? And, what do you feel you need more information on?

You will post your response to the submission area posted in the Week 2 module on canvas in either a Word document or a PDF.

**THIS PROPOSAL IS DUE BY FRIDAY JANUARY 17<sup>TH</sup> BY 11:59PM!**